

Collective Intelligence — Module 05: Action —

Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on team coordination, collective action, stigmergy, and the autonomy-alignment trade-off.

1. What distinguishes coordinated collective action from parallel individual action? Provide examples of each in a business context.
2. How does Wikipedia achieve coordination among hundreds of thousands of contributors without central authority? What is the Active Inference mechanism?
3. When is explicit coordination (plans, rules, schedules) more appropriate than implicit coordination (shared models, norms)? Give examples of each.
4. How do sports teams achieve implicit coordination? What would it take for a business team to develop the same level of "chemistry"?
5. The autonomy-alignment trade-off is fundamental. How do different organizational structures (hierarchy, flat, matrix) resolve this trade-off differently?
6. How does the level of task interdependence (parallel, sequential, reciprocal, intensive) determine the coordination mechanisms needed?
7. How do Kanban boards serve as stigmergic coordination tools? What other common work tools function stigmergically?
8. When does coordination overhead exceed the benefits of teamwork? How would you recognize this tipping point?
9. Compare coordination in a jazz ensemble (improvised) with coordination in an orchestra (scripted). Map each to team coordination archetypes.
10. How does remote work change the mechanisms of collective action? Which coordination modes (explicit, implicit, stigmergic) are most affected?

11. Analyze a recent collaborative project in your team. Was coordination primarily explicit, implicit, or stigmergic? What worked well, and what didn't?
12. Design a coordination system for a cross-functional team that must deliver a product in 90 days. Specify role assignments, communication protocols, and handoff mechanisms.
13. Your team consistently misses deadlines despite individual team members completing their tasks on time. Diagnose what is failing in the coordination system.
14. Compare how an agile sprint and a traditional waterfall phase manage collective action differently. Which provides better alignment? Which provides more autonomy?
15. Design a "coordination audit" that evaluates whether your team's coordination mechanisms match the task's interdependence level.
16. A team has too many coordination meetings. Propose a redesign that reduces coordination overhead while maintaining alignment.
17. How do shared tools (version control, project management software, communication platforms) change the collective action dynamics of teams?
18. When a team scales from 5 to 20 people, what coordination mechanisms must change? Why does "what worked for 5" often fail for 20?
19. How does conflict between team members affect collective action? When is conflict productive for coordination, and when is it destructive?
20. Design an experiment to test whether your team has developed implicit coordination (shared models that enable wordless coordination) or relies entirely on explicit coordination.